Happenings in Handmade

A CCI initiative

July 2025

WOVEN BY HAND, HELD BY HEART



The handwoven Chendamangalam saris of Kerala, crafted from fine cotton or silk, are part of a rich artisanal legacy. With their signature *puliyilakara* — a slender black border, and *chuttikara* — stripes or checks created through extra weft techniques, these saris have changed little since the time of the Cochin Maharajas. It was they who invited the Devanga Chettiars from Karnataka to settle in Chendamangalam and produce these refined textiles, which today hold GI status and continue to be worn during festivals and ceremonies.



The devastating Kerala floods of 2018 brought this community to its knees. Weaving sheds were flooded, yarns ruined, looms damaged, and finished stock destroyed. Livelihoods were lost overnight.



In response, five individuals from Chennai came together to form *Care for a Cause* (C4C). Visiting Chendamangalam, they saw the scale of devastation and resolved to do more than offer relief — they would create a roadmap for revival.



They adopted one of the seven weaving societies in the area, supporting 44 women weavers. Their mission: to uplift, upscale, and uphold traditional handloom weaving. They observed the lack of younger artisans and recognized the need to build both a sustainable future and a wider market for these products.



C4C
UPLIFT • UPSCALE • UPHOLD

In August 2018, the floods in Kerala brought devastation to Chendamangalam's historic weaving community displacing over 600 artisans and washing away their looms, livelihoods, and legacy.

Care4Chendamangalam was born from this crisis, supporting HWCS-648, a cooperative of 44 resilient women weavers. With a mission to uplift, upscale and uphold this rich handloom heritage, the trust has continued to stand by the community reviving not just their craft, but their confidence.

A three-year strategy was initiated to revive the cluster and train the next generation. C4C collaborated with Cochin-based designer Sreejith Jeevan of Rouka to reinterpret the classic Kerala sari. Traditional techniques — like *kattikara* stripes, extra weft motifs, and *kasavu* borders — were reimagined with modern, graphic finishes.





Weavers received training, upgraded wages, and healthcare support. Community gatherings were encouraged, fostering a renewed sense of unity. Slowly but steadily, the weavers began creating products with national and global appeal. Exhibitions followed in Cochin, Bangalore, Chennai, Delhi, and Mumbai. Recognition came when one of the weavers, Latha Gopalakrishnan, received the Sutrakar Samman 2023 award from the Delhi Crafts Council.



Today, the Chendamangalam cluster is a self-reliant and thriving unit. Where once there was despair, a collective effort brought dignity and direction — restoring not just livelihoods but also pride in tradition, one handwoven thread at a time.



Credits for images and video

Crafts Council of India

Kamala Store

C4C